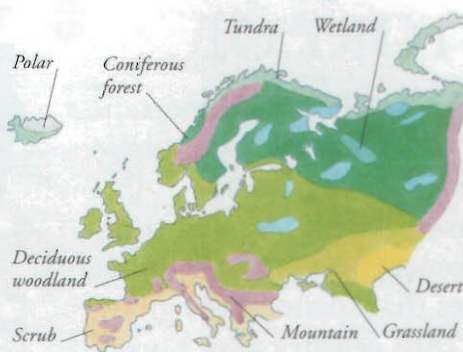


Climatic zones

Europe's position and varied landscape greatly affect its climate. Apart from the far north where it is always cold, European winters are generally cool, and summers warm or hot. Europe's west coast is milder because of the Gulf Stream, which brings warm waters northwards. Mountains, such as the Alps and Pyrenees, form a natural barrier, protecting the south from the rain and cold winds that blow from the north.



Only shallow-rooted plants can survive the cold.

Tundra

The extreme north of Europe lies inside the Arctic Circle and has a polar climate. The vegetation there is tundra – treeless plains where much of the subsoil is permanently frozen ground called permafrost. Only in summer does the topsoil thaw and plants flourish.

Taiga

In Russian, the word taiga means a marshy forest. The trees in the forests of northern Europe are mainly conifers, such as fir, larch, and pine. They keep their needle-like leaves even during the cold winters when they may be covered with snow for many months.

Deciduous woodland

Broad-leaved woods and forests are found in many parts of Europe. The trees, which lose their leaves in winter, include the quick-growing birch and ash, and the slower-growing, longer-lived beech, chestnut, maple, plane, and oak. Today, few ancient wild

forests survive, and most forest trees have been planted.

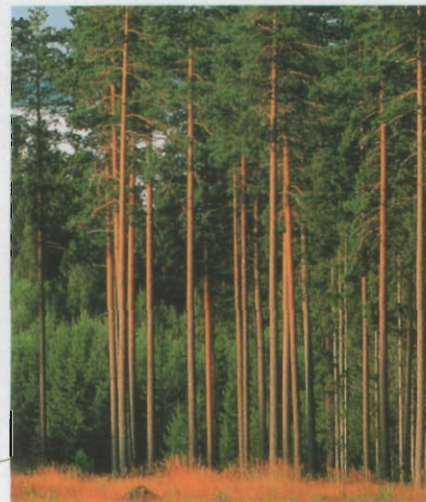


Oak leaves and acorns



Beech trees lose their dead leaves in spring when the new buds sprout.

Straight trunks provide timber for making paper, furniture, and boards.



Grasslands

Large areas of Europe, such as the central meseta region of Spain and the steppes of southern Russia and southeastern Ukraine, are covered in vast expanses of grassland. Much of this land is used for grazing animals and growing crops. Drought can be a problem in extreme summer temperatures.



During the spring the grass is lush and green, but becomes scorched as summer progresses.

Many plants have small leathery leaves so they can conserve water in the summer heat.

Ice, rain, and wind make it impossible for plants to survive on the peaks.



Garrigue

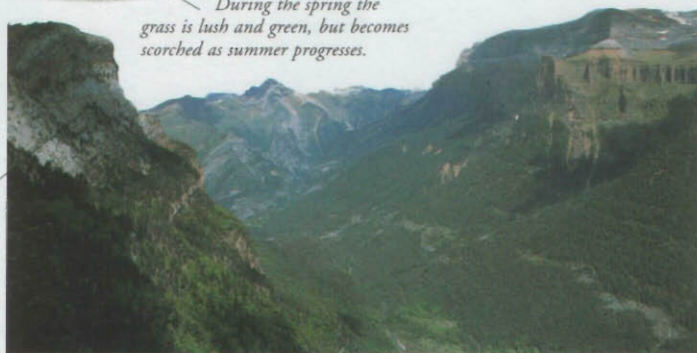
The warm dry hillsides close to the Mediterranean Sea in countries such as Spain, Greece, and France are covered with thorny, often aromatic plants and low bushes. On limestone soils this vegetation is called *garrigue*, elsewhere it is *maquis*.



Pine-needles and cone

Pyrenees

The Pyrenees form part of a vast arc of comparatively young mountains that stretch almost continuously across southern Europe and join with the Himalayas in Asia. Unlike the ancient mountains in Britain and Scandinavia, their shape is still changing because of plate movements beneath the Earth's crust. Mount Aneto is the highest peak at 3,404 m (12,962 ft).



People

Most Europeans live in densely populated towns and cities, many of which lie on the fertile North European Plain. Living standards are generally high compared with other parts of the world, and Europeans benefit from plentiful food and good healthcare. Many countries have sizeable ethnic minorities, usually from former colonies. The majority of Europeans are Christian.



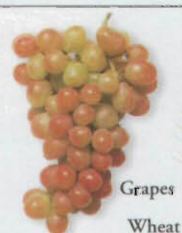
Finnish girl

Greek boy

French girl

Resources

Europe is rich in natural resources. More than half the land is used for farming a wide variety of food crops, from cereals, such as wheat, barley, and oats, to grapes, olives, citrus fruits, and salad vegetables. Europe mines 40 per cent of the world's coal and around 33 per cent of its iron ore. There are also large reserves of oil and natural gas, and lead, zinc, and other metals. Many rivers supply hydroelectric power.



Grapes

Wheat



Coal

FIND OUT MORE

CLIMATE

CONTINENTS

EUROPE, HISTORY OF

EUROPEAN WILDLIFE

FARMING

FORESTS

MOUNTAINS AND VALLEYS

ROCKS AND MINERALS

TREES

TUNDRA